

The Narrative Context of Moral Theory
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If it is unusual it is perhaps not entirely inappropriate to consider the narrative context of moral science in (I promise) brief narrative form. The fact is that I have very little claim on your scholarly attention, since I know very little about any area of scholarship, and since I plan--can you believe it--to touch on several. But I do have a series of questions which seem to me important ones, and I think that considering the perspective of one who does not know is an illuminating exercise even for those who more nearly know. So permit me to start with a bit of highly compressed personal history.

My earliest exposure to St. Thomas was unsystematic, but I was taken with admiration for him, and so became deeply troubled by the possibility that his understanding of predestination was morally offensive. After what I thought were my best efforts to unseat this possibility no longer seemed promising, I decided to take Thomas Kuhn's advice. I had heard him suggest that to grasp a worldview which seemed plainly false, one should imagine that the most evidently false element of it were surely true, and proceed to construct the rest of the picture around that imaginatively certain claim.

And so I came to prayerfully considered whether I could face my loving Creator on the presumption that my salvation and indeed all my free choices were entirely directed by Him. To my surprise I found that I could, and thereby came to know compatibilist free

agency. The possibility of reprobation remained, as Maritain noted, "obscurissima". But it occurred to me that it was possible that God could not predestine all free creatures without loss of some greater good. That human beings were by nature entirely part of a complex and dynamic causal order of finite creatures whose proper causality could be and inevitably would be sometimes impeded, and thus that the permission of sin was metaphysically necessary for the existence of human beings: this possibility seemed no less initially plausible to me than the claim that God was entirely the first cause of the distinction between the predestined and the reprobate. If all that were true, I thought, love—that is, God—impels us to create the sorts of conditions in which human beings would hear the gospel in a way enabling them to effectively respond to it, conditions which the gospel assured me involved a way of life in which we love one another.

Soon thereafter I came to believe that the creation of such conditions—the task of Aristotelian politics—might well be the subject of a genuine science.

Once I came to grasp Kuhn's account of scientific progress, coupled with Alasdair MacIntyre's craft-tradition overcoming of Kuhnian relativism so familiar to those gathered here, I came to understand a pattern of scientific inquiry which could in principle be applied to other areas of inquiry, and which may have been applied successfully by Plato, Aristotle, and Aquinas to rational inquiry whole and entire. On the craft-tradition picture, first principles from all areas of inquiry are justified insofar as dialectical inquiry reveals them to be necessary elements of a whole system with greater explanatory, predictive, and

directive power than any rival thus far to emerge. Such a system has the intelligible pattern of a story, an overview of human nature, surroundings, origin, purpose, and progress; the first principles of each area of inquiry can thus be spoken of as being set in a narrative context. Any narrative describing substantial progress in rational inquiry will be the story of a community working common theoretical and practical problems over a period of time sufficient for progress to be discerned. So rational inquiry can only progress under substantially unified and stable social conditions... conditions, I readily saw, rather like ones in which I was then living.

For twenty years, now, I have been living as part of a community of hundreds of people who have permanently committed ourselves to live our lives together by the power of the Holy Spirit. Hundreds of times for formal teaching and thousands for worship and ten thousands in the normal business of everyday life I have interacted in love with people who are united with me both in an ever-more deep and common understanding of the gospel and in a shared pattern of life according which our efforts in response to the gospel are directed. The unity and the duration of our life together have enabled me to see more clearly how a conception of the good life can become enriched, and how much progress can be made toward organizing patterns of social interaction in such a way as to regularly envision, pursue, and obtain the good life according to that conception. Of course, our understanding of the good life is informed by Revealed Truth, and none of us understand the gospel to be merely the best account of the good life so far to have emerged. Yet regarding how the gospel is to be understood, propagated and responded to, there is considerable room for

progress. What will constitute progress in each of these ways will depend upon which narrative context guides the inquiry. My own efforts to get an overview have been shaped by my unsystematic reading of St. Thomas, but also in part by the following observations.

Modern science has made possible in certain ways an ever-greater understanding and appreciation of the spatial and temporal vastness, the complexity, the order, the grandeur, the poetry of the universe. It seems to me not implausible that life, even intelligent life, was created through a process of unfolding of the causal implications of the physical universe over billions of years. Human beings seem to have evolved from lower forms of life, although--the church teaches and thus I accept--the human soul remains a special creation. Yet the history of interaction between theological and natural science suggests to me at once a cautious and imaginative approach to their interfacing. Is it possible that the soul of a human being is to be identified with some particular vitalizing pattern of information, some particular form which includes its genetic structure? Is it possible that the special creation of the human soul adds nothing to the causality of the created causes but a special intention, a special concern for the good of each individual human being and for the special role which human beings play in the plan of Providence?

These and related questions occupy my unscholarly speculation. The questions themselves suggest to me that an awareness of the dignity of the physical order, and a tendency not to underestimate what can be explained in terms of it, are ways in which modern science

ought to condition my attempt to arrive at an adequate narrative context for understanding the good life and how to achieve it.

It seems that there is a sense in which modern science is more like science because it is less like modern: modern, as characterized by a confidence in the universally applicable and accessible power of Reason to liberate human kind from the tyranny of authority and tradition. Postmodern critiques have drawn attention to the social character of thought and have eroded all but the vestiges of a conception of tradition-independent and even -hostile reason, even as science (at its best) welcomes challenges to prevailing paradigms from all comers and progresses tentatively, slowly building toward traditions which stand as the best accounts so far, always testing and revising. But in spite of their effective erosion of confidence in reason, postmodern critiques have left standing another and related modern legacy: an increased awareness of the fundamental equality and dignity of human persons. In what seems like the offspring of a marriage of strange bedfellows, the modern emphasis on the equal dignity of persons and the postmodern recognition of diverse social contexts of thought have together awakened a greater respect for cultural diversity, for political and religious liberty, and for freedom of conscience.

This heightened awareness of the dignity of humanity and of respect for diverse modes of life and thought are--in the language of *Gaudium et Spes*--among the signs of the times to be interpreted in light of the gospel. But is not, in a different way, the gospel to be interpreted in light of the signs of the times, insofar as there is discerned in them an authentic move of

the Holy Spirit? Respect for human dignity and for diverse ways of life were highlighted in the teaching of the Second Vatican Council to a degree unprecedented in Sacred Tradition. Reflection on the gospel in light of these themes has so transformed not the gospel but contemporary awareness of its meaning that John Paul II could summarize it this way: “To accept the Gospel’s demands means to affirm all our humanity, to see in it the beauty desired by God, while at the same time recognizing, in light of the power of God Himself, our weaknesses... (*Crossing the Threshold of Hope*, CTH).”

Nor is it the dignity of humanity alone which is achieving greater emphasis in the development of Sacred Tradition. Increased awareness of and respect for the whole created order brings greater insight into what it is that (in the words of St. Paul) “will be set free from its bondage to decay and obtain the glorious liberty of the children of God.” John Paul II has commented on the development of tradition in this way: “It can be said that until recently the Church’s catechesis and preaching centered upon an individual eschatology, one, for that matter, which is profoundly rooted in Divine Revelation. The vision proposed by the Council, however, was of an eschatology of the Church and of the world (CTH).” The Pope goes on to quote from *Lumen Gentium* Ch. VII, which refers to a time when “the human race, together with the entire world, which is intimately connected to man and through him arrives at its destiny, will be perfectly renewed in Christ “It must be admitted”, the Holy Father continues “that this eschatological vision was only faintly present in traditional preaching.... Eschatology . . . is profoundly anthropological, but . . . it is above all centered on Christ and the Holy Spirit, and it is also, in a certain sense, cosmic (CTH).”

This emerging emphasis on the meaning of God's "plan for the fulness of time, to unite all things in Christ, things in heaven and things on Earth" of course raises a good number of questions. The Council Fathers commented on some of them in this way: "We do not know the time for the consummation of the earth and of humanity. Nor do we know how all things will be transformed. As deformed by sin, the shape of this world will pass away. But we are taught that God is preparing a new dwelling place and a new earth where justice will abide, and whose blessedness will answer and surpass all the longings for peace which spring up in the human heart. . . . For after we have obeyed the Lord, and in His Spirit nurtured on earth the values of human dignity, brotherhood, and freedom, and indeed all the good fruits of our nature and enterprise, we will find them again, but freed of stain . . . and transfigured (*Gaudium et Spes* 39)."

Recent developments in Scripture scholarship--especially in the work of N. T. Wright--highlight three elements suggested by the Council's eschatological vision: that all human hopes will be fulfilled in a renewed earth, not in a heaven unconnected with this created physical order; that salvation has a corporate and not primarily an individual focus; and that salvation is cosmic and not anthropocentric in scope.

Wright argues at length that there is virtually no evidence that either 1st century Jewish writers or the evangelists were expecting the end of the space-time universe; the widespread belief that they were is based on "a simple misreading of their use of Jewish

apocalyptic language, whose real referent is the end of the present world order." Again from Wright: "The myth of 'apocalyptic' Christianity, then, needs radical revision. To be sure, the early Christians continued to use 'apocalyptic' language. But all the evidence suggests that they used it very much as first-century Jews did, i.e., to invest space-time reality with theological significance. Problems about 'taking it literally' only arise, in modern and perhaps ancient readings, when the Jewish background is ignored or misunderstood."

On mainstream Jewish and Christian accounts, the end of the present world order involves the creation of a people faithful to God's commands. Salvation, rather than being a matter of individual rescue from a corrupt and failing physical world, was for first century Jews—again, from Wright—"a matter of a new world, the renewal of creation. Within this, Israel's god would call some from within the nation to be a new Israel, the spearhead of the divine purpose. Within this again, this renewed people were to be the holy, pure, renewed human beings, living in a covenant fidelity ... which would end in the renewal, i.e., the resurrection, of human bodies themselves. When this god acted, those who belonged, by his grace alone, to this group, would be rescued, and thereby vindicated as the true people of god that they had claimed to be all along. Those who had died in advance of that day would be raised in order to share it." Wright argues that from the very beginning, Christian self-understanding was intimately tied to this notion of a faithful people who were the fulfillment of the story of Israel.

Finally, the story of Israel, and hence of the new Israel, is understood to be a chapter within a larger story. Wright argues that "Luke's gospel is intended to be the final scene in the story of the creator god and his covenant people, and hence the penultimate scene... in a larger drama still, that of the creator god and the world." Wright offers this version of the larger drama recounted in scripture: "... reality as we know it is the result of a Creator god bringing into being a world that is other than himself, and yet which is full of his glory. It was always the intention of this God that creation should one day be flooded with his own life, in a way for which it was prepared from the beginning. As part of the means to this end, the creator brought into being a creature which, by bearing the creator's image, would bring his wise and loving care to bear upon the creation. By a tragic irony, the creature in question has rebelled against this intention. But the creator has solved this problem in principle in an entirely appropriate way, and as a result is now moving the creation once more towards its originally intended goal. The implementation of this solution now involves the Indwelling of this god within his human creatures and ultimately within the whole creation, transforming it into that for which it was made in the beginning."

This drama is the story of the origins and purposes of this space-time reality, this physical world; God's plan is to enter this universe, not to replace it with something else. Human destiny is not a private, might-as-well-be disembodied eternal audience with god, but rather a union with him through full incorporation into a people in whom God dwells and with whom he cooperates to manifest his loving and intelligent order in this space-time universe. Fundamentally, this is a story about god and the whole created order, not about

us. All three of what seem to be changes in emphasis in second Vatican council eschatology—its focus on the completion, not the cancellation, of history; on salvation as life in a redeemed humanity; and on the whole created order--seem to be supported by the story found in scripture, on Wright's telling.

Without pretending a conclusion, let me end by drawing out a line of questions which are suggested to me in part by these reflections.

Isn't it vitally important for any area of inquiry to get the big picture, the narrative context, right? This importance is indicated at the level of theory by the craft-tradition model of rationality, according to which the first principles of every science receive their justification from the explanatory, predictive, and directive power of the whole system of which they form part. The importance of narrative context is suggested, too, by the phenomena of sudden reorientation, illustrated by my experience of grappling with the doctrine of predestination. I think also that the importance of the big picture can be felt in the unsettledness and resistance which accompanies the telling of a rival narrative--such as the eschatological story I just sketched--which hits too close to home and threatens (if just a little) to subvert our worldview.

Now, questions only.

Thomistic ethics?

Can the right narrative context be discerned without a rich grasp of the status of inquiry at all the relevant levels, including, notably, the natural sciences and theology?

Can any individual today attain the kind of masterful grasp of human inquiry required for the formulation of an adequate overview of the created order?

Can any community of persons cooperate effectively toward the formation of such an overview unless they share a substantially common way of life?

Can such a substantially common life be based upon anything other than an attempt to fully live out the gospel?

Is “natural” moral philosophy, conducted in abstraction from revealed truth, a credible category for Christian rational inquiry? In what sort of enacted narrative would the meaning of its deliverance be adequately discovered?

Finally, isn't the need for a new kind of highest order, socially-embodied inquiry--a new kind of university, along the lines sketched by Macintyre in *Three Rival Versions*, perhaps--suggested by the need to find an adequate narrative context for enquiry?